

NAHUM

THE PROPHECY OF NAHUM.

PREFACE.

Nahum, whose name signifies a comforter, was a native of Elcesai, or Elcesai, supposed to be a little town in Galilee. He prophesied after the ten tribes were carried into captivity, and foretold the utter destruction of Ninive by the Babylonians and Medes; which happened in the reign of Josias, (Ch.) in the sixteenth year, when the father of Nabuchodonosor and the grandfather of Cyrus entirely ruined Ninive, and divided the empire between them, (C.) A.

3378. Usher. Tob.

xiv. 16. --- Nahum was probably on the spot when he proclaimed this beautiful prediction, which yields not to any work of profane authors. He might have been carried captive by Salmanasar, as he alludes to the captivity of Israel and to the blasphemies of Sennacherib. We cannot, therefore, place his prophecy before the fifteenth year of Ezechias. C. -- - He appeared about fifty years after Jonas, when the Ninivites had relapsed, and were destroyed in the space of one hundred and thirty-five years, as a figure of the subversion of idolatry by Christ's preaching the gospel of peace. W.

NAHUM 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 1. Burden, or threat. W. --- Sept. "assumption," (H.) when the prophet saw in spirit the impending ruin. Theod. --- Allegorically, Nahum is "the comforter"

of the just, shewing that God will avenge their cause against Ninive, "the beautiful," and destroy the world, (kosmos, which also means "beautiful,") after which the saints shall reign in eternal glory. W. ---

We have describe Ninive. Jonas i. C. --- It was overturned first A. 3257, and again A. 3378. Usher.

Elcesite. Some think that Elcesai was the father of Nahum; but most suppose that it was a village Galilee. C.

Ver. 2. The Lord. The six following verses (H.) tend to excite attention. C.

Ver. 3. Cleanse. Literally, cleansing, he will not make innocent." H. --- The same expression is rendered, No man of himself is innocent before thee. Ex. xxxiv. 7.

C. --- Sept. "the innocent he will not deem innocent." H. --- No man is perfect in God's sight, (C.) though they may appear to be such to others. H. --- None can escape punishment, if he be treated with rigour. De Dieu translates, "he will not utterly evacuate," or destroy, which seems very correct. Jer. xxx. 11.

Num. xiv. 18. --- Dust. He walks upon them as we do on dry land.

Ver. 4. Desert, as at the Red Sea. Ps. cv. 9. --- Languisheth. The most fruitful places produce nothing, when God is angry.

Ver. 5. Made. Sept. "shaken." --- Quaked. Heb. and Sept. "risen." C.

Ver. 6. Like fire. Sept. "melts kingdoms."

Ver. 7. Hope. Sept. "fear." He approves of his faithful servants. H.

Ver. 8. Thereof; viz. of Ninive. Ch. --- This is connected with v. 1. H. --- Ninive was taken by the waters of the Tigris overflowing, at the first siege. Diod. ii.

Athen. xii. --- The like might happen at the second, though profane authors be silent. C. --- Many think that the flood means great armies. Is. viii. 7. Forer. Vat.

--- Sept. "He will utterly destroy: those who rise up and his enemies, darkness," &c. H. --- Chal. The. and Aq. adopt the same sense, but Sym. &c.

agree with us. C.

Ver. 9. Affliction. Sept. add, "for the same thing, or together." H. --- :Many hence infer, that those who have been slain by God, like the Sodomites, &c.

will not be condemned to hell. Orig.

i. Ezech. S. Jer. S. Th. 3. p. q. 59. a. 5. --- But this principle cannot be always correct. C. --- Their temporal suffering might usher in eternal ones. S. Greg.

Mor. xviii. 12. --- Ninive shall perish; so that a second blow will not be requisite.

1 K. xxvi. 8. Drus. C.

Ver. 10. Dry. The Assyrians, feasting in the hopes that they would speedily become masters of Jerusalem, were cut off in one night. W. --- God's enemies cannot escape; as when a thorn bush has taken fire, all must perish. Ps. lvii.

10. Is. ix. 18. C.

Ver. 11. Forth. Some understand this of Sennacherib. But as his attempt against the people seems to have been prior to the prophecy of Nahum, we may better understand it of Holofernes.

Ch. --- One. Sept. "a most wicked thought against the Lord, devising opposition." H. --- We may render, "hath come," &c. alluding to Sennacherib and Rabsaces. Is. xxxvi. 18. and xxxvii. 23. C.

Ver. 12. Perfect. That is, however strong or numerous their forces may be, they shall be cut off, and their prince or leader shall pass away and disappear. Ch.

--- If there were many just at Ninive, or among the Jews, (C.) a moderate chastisement would suffice. H. --- The latter have been afflicted; now their enemies shall suffer. Sept. have read otherwise: (C.) "the Lord, reigning over the great waters; thus shall they be divided, and thou shalt be heard of no more." H.

Ver. 13. Asunder. Ezechias was tributary to Assyria. 4 K. xviii. 14. After the fall of Ninive, its yoke was removed. C.

Ver. 14. Commandment. That is, a decree concerning thee, O king of Ninive, thy seed shall fail,

&c. Ch. --- His son Asarhaddon succeeded; but soon the line was extinct. W. ---

No alarm shall be spread by thee. --- Grave. Sennacherib was slain in the temple: (Is. xxxvii. 38. C.) or the idols were deemed unclean by the victors.

Eurip. Troad. H.

Ver. 15. Peace. Sentinels were established on the hills. --- Festivals. S. Jerom quotes the B. of Paral. as saying (C.) that the Jews could not observe the Passover in the first month. But they did it in the second, after they knew that Sennacherib was slain. 2 Par. xxxii. H. --- This passage does not, however, appear at present in Scripture, and it could not speak of the second month (C.) following Nisan, (H.) as the king was slain forty-five days (Tob. i. 22. Gr. 55.) after his return to Ninive; and some time must have elapsed before he could get thither, and the news arrive in Judea. C. --- Belial; the wicked one, viz. the Assyrian. Ch.

NAHUM 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. Face, O Juda. Sept. "who blows on thy face, (Gen. ii. 7.) freeing from misery." Here S.

Jerom's Gr. copy ends the chap. H. --- Watch. Behold Nabopolassar is about to attack thy enemies. Some think that Nahum addresses Ninive ironically. C. ---

Nabuchodonosor wasted all the environs, and then took the city (W.) after his other conquests. C. --- But his father is here denoted. H.

Ver. 2. Pride, &c. He hath punished Jacob for his pride; and therefore Ninive must not expect to escape. Or else, rendering the pride of Jacob means rewarding, that is, punishing Ninive for the pride they exercised against Jacob.

Ch. --- After the Assyrians had seized the ten tribes, they became more insolent, and are therefore punished. W. --- The haughty Phul, &c. had invaded the Israelites, and had taken them into captivity. This God will now resent, (C.) though he justly chastised his people by them. H.

Ver. 3. Mighty men. He speaks of the Chaldeans and Medes sent to destroy the Ninivites. Ch. ---

This is the common opinion. Yet it seems rather that the Ninivites are designated, as they were asleep and stumbled, &c. C. --- Stupified. That is, they drive on furiously, like men intoxicated with wine. Ch. --- Heb. "the fir-tree shall be shaken," or poisoned. Ps. cxix. 4. Sept. read better, (C.) "their horsemen shall be in a hurry, or in confusion." H. --- The armour was kept very shining, and the soldiers of Cyrus were clothed in purple, like himself. Xen. iii.

--- Yet this availed nothing, while the men were asleep or confounded. C.

Ver. 4. Streets. The Ninivites are disordered at the enemy's approach. S. Jer.

Ver. 5. Muster. Lit. "remember" (H.) the ancient heroes, Salmanasar, &c. C. ---

**Stumble, by running hastily on. Ch. --- Prepared to defend the city. H. -
-- All this represents a city surprised.**

It attempts to defend itself; but God renders all efforts vain. C.

**Ver. 6. Gates; floodgates or channel of the Tigris overflowing. C. i. 8. ---
Temple.**

Sept.

"palace."

**Ver. 7. Soldier. Heb. hutsab, (H.) "the station" or guard; the queen, or
the statue of the idol, with the women (C.) who prostituted themselves
in its honour.**

Sanct. xxxi. --- Ninive and its dependances are taken. Grot.

**Ver. 8. Waters: multitudes, (Apoc. xvii. 15.) and riches; (C.) or the flood
bursting upon them makes them flee. H. --- The citizens run away when
the enemy had made a breach, as water does when the dam is broken
down; and though some more valiant will exhort them to tarry, they
will not succeed, nor save the city. W.**

Ver. 10. Kettle. In mourning they blacken their face. Tav. Perse.

**Ver. 11. Lions. The kings of Assyria had plundered various nations, (H.)
and had brought the spoils to Ninive. But all shall be lost. W. --- These
princes followed no law but their own will.**

**--- The lion, Nabopolassar, or his son: though it seems rather to relate
to the Assyrian monarchs.**

C.

**Ver. 13. Chariots. Sept. "multitude." Some wild beasts were thus
suffocated in their dens.**

Theod. --- More, like that of the impious Rabsaces. 4 K. xviii. 17. C.

NAHUM 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. Blood. Nemrod established his power by shedding blood. Gen. x. Ninus, who built Ninive, and his successors were also bloody. After 1200 years the empire decayed under Sardanapalus, as historians agree. Yet it continued longer, according to the Scriptures and Ribera, till the Chaldees destroyed it, when it had subsisted about 1440 years. It was even possessed of great power after the return of the Jews from Babylon, as Eus. S. Aug. V. Bede, &c. write.

W. ---

Depart. Sept. "be touched." H. --- He continues the metaphor of the lion seizing its prey. Here the last chapter should end.

Ver. 2. The noise. He has described the forces of Ninive, now he specifies those of Cyaxares and Nabopolassar.

Ver. 4. Harlot. Ninive is cruel and impure, engaging others in idolatry and witchcraft. C. ---

Sold, forcing them to adopt her manners. Rom. vii. 14.

Ver. 7. Bemoan. Lit. "shake his head:" the latter words are not in Heb. H. ---

Some supply, move his lips: but head will answer as well. This is a sign of derision or of pity. Job xlii. 11.

Mat. xxvii. 39. C.

Ver. 8. Populous Alexandria. No-Amon. A populous city of Egypt, destroyed by the Chaldeans, and afterwards rebuilt by Alexander, and called Alexandria.

Others suppose No-Amon to be the same as Diospolis. Ch. --- This seems preferable, as it was amidst waters and near the Mediterranean.

Profane historians take little notice of it, as it was greatly reduced. Bochart fixes upon Memphis, others upon the temple of Ammon. But these were too remote from the sea. C.

--- The former was however near the Nile, (H.) which is sometimes called a sea.

C. --- S. Jerom thinks that Alexandria stood on the ruins of No. W. --- Yet of this we have no proof. It is thought that Nahum alludes to the devastation caused by Nabuchodonosor. As Juda however was still in his kingdom, it seems rather that Assaraddon, (Is. xx.) or his predecessor, Sennacherib, (C.) laid waste this city. 4 K. xviii. 21. Usher, A. 3292.

Ver. 9. Ethiopia; Chus, in Arabia, not far from Diospolis.

Ver. 10. Captivity. It was afterwards re-established and taken by Nabuchodonosor. C. ---

Fetters, or stocks. H.

Ver. 11. Drunk, and be chastised by God. Ezech. xxiii. 32. --- From, to escape.

Ver. 14. Water. This was a necessary precaution. 2 Par. xxxii. 3. --- Brick, to repair the breaches.

Ver. 15. Locust. Yet all will be in vain. Thy numbers will be cut off as easily as locusts.

Ver. 16. Away. Thus did the merchants, at the approach of the enemy.

Ver. 17. Guards. Heb. "crowned" princes. --- Little. Heb. "satraps are like great locusts, which,"

&c. S. Jerom has read (C.) toppic instead of taphseraic, (H.) which Sept.

neglect. Thapsar denotes an officer. Jer. li. 27. C. --- Of locusts. The young locusts. Ch.

Ver. 18. Slumbered. They have not guarded the flock. C.

Ver. 19. Hidden. Heb. and Sept. "irremediable." H. --- No one pities thy wound.

Chal. C.